"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, mostly sunny, a light breeze from the north-northwest, high 66. **Tonight,** clear, a breeze out of the north, low 46. **Tomorrow,** sunshine, high 57. Weather map, Page A24.

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GLEB GARANICH/REUTERS

In Kyiv, on Wednesday, an apartment building damaged in an attack by jet drones, as civilian deaths in Ukraine have climbed of late.

As Putin Frees American, U.S. Sees 'Humanitarian'

WHITE HOUSE MEMO

Trump Views Insults as One-Way Street

By PETER BAKER

OSLO — The rules of the road when it comes to President Trump's relations with foreign leaders are clear: He may trash you. But woe unto you if you whack back.

No one knows that better than President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine, who has been through this particular diplomatic wringer more than once. But he got a pointed reminder during a closed-door meeting in Oslo this week with Mr. Trump's negotiators.

Steve Witkoff, the president's special envoy, and Jared Kushner, the president's son-in-law, reproached Mr. Zelensky on Tuesday for his sharp comments responding to Mr. Trump's sharp comments about him, telling the Ukrainian leader that the way he had conducted himself had infuriated the president, according to a person informed about the exchange.

Mr. Zelensky pushed back at times during the discussion as the Americans complained about certain remarks. "I never said that," Mr. Zelensky insisted at one point, according to the person, who shared details on the condition of anonymity because it was a private conversation. But he clearly got the message. When he addressed journalists afterward, a subdued Mr. Zelensky strained to offer a positive assessment while sidestepping his recent criticisms of Mr. Trump.

"We are thankful to the American side," Mr. Zelensky said, citing the resumption of U.S. intelligence help. He noted that he had spoken with Secretary of State Marco Rubio on his way to Oslo, which produced "positive signals from the American side" and that he had a "very constructive dialogue" with Mr. Witkoff and Mr. Kushner. "But," he added, "it was very constructive between us because all of us want peace: Ukraine, Europe, United States."

The one-way-street school of diplomacy has worked for Mr. Trump in the sense that his belligerence leaves many world leaders reluctant to cross him for fear of blowback or even, depending on his mood, a fresh round of tariffs. Mr. Trump demands deference while rarely

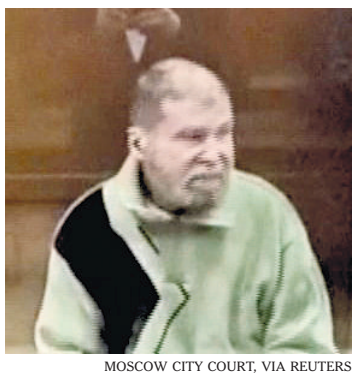
Continued on Page A9

Envoy Praises Head of Russia, as Kyiv Faces Pushback

This article is by ***David E. Sanger****,* ***Kim Barker*** *and* ***Ivan Nechepurenko****.*

WASHINGTON — Praising President Vladimir V. Putin as a "humanitarian," President Trump's special envoy, Steve Witkoff, thanked the Russian leader in St. Petersburg on Wednesday for releasing an American held for more than four years on what the State Department called fabricated charges.

The release came after Mr. Trump made a direct appeal last week to Mr. Putin to let the 74-year-old teacher, Stephen James Hubbard, return to the United States. Russia had accused Mr. Hubbard, who was held for over four years, of being a Ukrainian mercenary and sentenced him to



MOSCOW CITY COURT, VIA REUTERS

Stephen James Hubbard in an image from a 2024 video.

more than six years in a penal colony. Mr. Hubbard had been seized by Russian troops in Ukraine, where he was living, but there was no evidence he was involved in the battle after Russia's invasion.

"You talk so much about my president, President Trump, being a humanitarian," Mr. Witkoff told Mr. Putin, whom he was meeting to discuss another variant of plans to end the war. "You are a humanitarian also, sir, and I salute that."

The phrase hung in the air because Mr. Putin, who started a war of aggression against Ukraine that has led to the deaths of tens of thousands of Ukrainian soldiers and civilians, is wanted as a war criminal by the International Criminal Court. Mr. Trump, who has repeatedly expressed sympathies for strongmen and parroted Kremlin talking points, has long made clear his admiration for the

Continued on Page A10

TRUMP'S RATING HITS A NEW LOW

Likely Voters Are Tilting Toward Democrats

By LISA LERER and RUTH IGIELNIK

President Trump's approval rating hit a new low just a few weeks before the midterm elections, driven down by broad disapproval of his handling of the economy, the war in Iran and high gas prices, according to a new national poll from The New York Times and Siena University.

Just 36 percent of likely voters said that they approved of Mr. Trump's performance, while 59 percent said that they disapproved. That is his lowest approval rating recorded in any Times/Siena poll. More than two-thirds of independent voters said that they disapproved of the way he has handled his job as president.

Likely voters said that they preferred Democratic candidates over Republicans by 11 percentage points in their congressional districts in the final Times/Siena national poll before the midterm elections, a slight improvement for Democrats since last month. The metric is widely seen as a strong indicator of political momentum.

The national political environment is bleak for Republicans. Americans broadly disapprove of economic conditions under the Trump administration, with three-quarters rating the economy as fair or poor. A majority of voters blame Mr. Trump for the decline: 69 percent disapprove of his handling of the cost of living, 65 percent disapprove of his handling of the war in Iran and nearly three-quarters disapprove of his handling of gas prices, which are above $4 a gallon.

But Democrats still face serious challenges, particularly as they seek to win control of the Senate. To do so they are trying to flip seats in Republican-leaning states including Texas, Iowa, Alaska and Ohio, which Mr. Trump won by double digits in 2024. Other polls show that Democrats and Republicans are locked in tight races in several key Senate contests.

Still, the deep economic frustration has even broken into the coalition that elected Mr. Trump to his second term. Over the past year, Democrats have improved their standing among men, young voters and Hispanic voters — win-

Continued on Page A18

Billionaire's Pardon Hope and a $50 Million Deal

Venezuelan Man Gains Clemency After Job Offer to Trump Ally

By TYLER PAGER

WASHINGTON — Julio Herrera Velutini really wanted a pardon.

A billionaire banker from a prominent Venezuelan family, Mr. Herrera faced felony bribery charges in the United States and struck an unusually lenient plea deal in August 2025 for a misdemeanor campaign finance violation. But he felt that reduced charge was still a stain on his record.

So Mr. Herrera deployed his lawyer, Christopher M. Kise, the former Florida solicitor general who was on President Trump's personal legal team, to help with a plea for clemency. His 27-year-old daughter, Isabela Herrera, who is an American citizen, donated $3.5 million to a super PAC tied to Mr. Trump. But as of last fall, the pardon remained elusive.

Then the Herrera family hired Alina Habba, who had been one of Mr. Trump's personal lawyers and at the time was an adviser at the Justice Department. They offered her $10 million a year for four years along with a range of bonuses. In total, including bonuses, she was guaranteed more than $50 million over four years, according to interviews and documents obtained by The New York Times.

Under the agreement, Ms. Habba would become general counsel at Concord Partners, a company that Ms. Herrera set up in late October 2025 in Florida. The company has no public profile and its business remains unclear even to some people associated with the Herrera business empire. Ms. Habba finalized her deal days after the company was registered, while she was still serving as U.S.

Continued on Page A14



JUNG YEON-JE/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

Rescue Effort in South Korea
A shark, who'd become a local celebrity after getting stuck in a canal, was guided back to the ocean.

Meta Is Ordered to Pay $25 Billion Over Privacy

43 Million Violations in New Mexico Ruling

By ELI TAN and CECILIA KANG

SAN FRANCISCO — A New Mexico judge ordered Meta to pay $25 billion on Wednesday for deceiving users about its data privacy practices, one of the largest penalties levied against a tech giant.

New Mexico sued Meta in 2021 over a scandal involving the political consulting firm Cambridge Analytica, saying the social media company had misled users with its public statements about their data privacy. Last month, after a two-week trial, a jury in the State District Court in Santa Fe ruled against Meta, saying the company had committed 43 million violations of New Mexico's consumer protection laws. Each violation carried a penalty of up to $5,000.

On Wednesday, Judge Francis J. Mathew of the State District Court in Santa Fe issued the landmark penalty, writing that the company and its executives purposefully misled the public.

"The harm in this matter is difficult to overstate, and goes to the heart of Facebook's basic business proposition," Judge Mathew wrote in a 20-page judgment. He

Continued on Page A16

Kyiv Says Drones Fell From Sky As U.S.-Backed Service Cut Out

This article is by ***Siobhán O'Grady****,* ***Carlotta Gall*** *and* ***Anton Troianovski****.*

KYIV, Ukraine — A senior Ukrainian commander said he had dozens of armed drones soaring toward Russian military targets last week when, all at once, the video feeds streaming their flight paths went fuzzy.

The drones had lost their connection to pilots on the ground through Starshield, a Pentagon-funded satellite internet service, said the commander, Oleh, who spoke on the condition that he be identified by only his first name to protect operational security. Many of the drones simply fell from the sky, he said: The effect cost his units more than $1 million worth of weaponry.

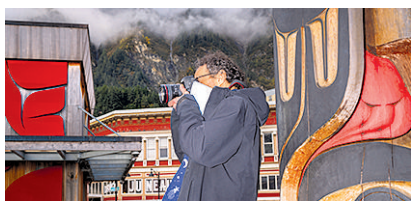
The Starshield disruptions forced Oleh to halt almost all operations for the next three days, he said, including strikes on Russian command posts and fuel hubs. Such attacks, he said, help save the lives of Ukrainian troops holding positions on the front and slow Russian advances.

Ukrainian accounts of Starshield's abrupt throttling have become a flashpoint in a worsening feud between President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine and President Trump. A week after the first problems were reported, Ukrainian troops said that the situation had improved but that connectivity issues remained. The Trump administration has offered mixed messages, both denying any change to Starshield service and saying that service has been restored.

Ukrainian officials fear that the Trump administration ordered the disruptions to punish Ukraine over its strikes on Russian oil refineries and to force Kyiv to capitulate in the war. Ukraine has also reported gaps in the sharing of U.S. military intelligence and delays in the delivery of American interceptor missiles. U.S. officials deny any such disruptions.

Starshield is a military-grade

Continued on Page A9



BUSINESS B1-6

Alaska's Journalists Join Forces
The state's taxing geography and newspapers' economic reality have stretched reporters covering the election. PAGE B1

Signs in Black Jobless Rate
As the Black unemployment rate rises, economists warn that the job market is weaker than it appears. PAGE B1

INTERNATIONAL A4-12

Data Center Backlash in U.K.
Plans to build one of Europe's largest A.I. facilities in Devon have been met by strong opposition from residents, as environmental concerns grow. PAGE A4

NATIONAL A13-21, 24

A.I. Uncovers Security Flaw
A bug was found in widely used internet software, revealing a new vulnerability to hacker disruptions. PAGE A16

Idaho's Health Coverage Crisis
The state's public health clinics struggle to provide care as insurance premiums rise and Medicaid cuts kick in. PAGE A20



THURSDAY STYLES D1-8

Fighting Through a Whiteout
In a new book, Wendy S. Walters takes issue with the unimaginative default of painting walls white. PAGE D2

Beyond Downtown Mocking
As Nolita Dirtbag, Alex Hartman has made a mark with his online critiques. Now he's expanding his gaze. PAGE D7

SPORTS B7-10

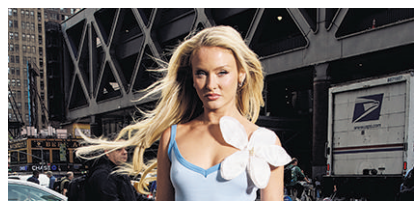
When James Calls, You Answer
Nick Nurse, the coach of the 76ers, was on a golf course when his phone buzzed. His conversation with LeBron James would alter the N.B.A. PAGE B7

OBITUARIES B11-12

An Advocate for the Miniskirt
Felicity Green was a London fashion editor in the Swinging Sixties, when skimpy styles and their required undergarments ruled. She was 100. PAGE B11

OPINION A22-23

The Editorial Board PAGE A22



ARTS C1-8

Pop Hanger-On to Superstar
Sweden's Zara Larsson broke out at 10 but found success this past year with her "Midnight Sun" album, popular remixes and TikTok virality. PAGE C1